

« BEFORE

The US had bases across South Vietnam, but Tan Son Nhut airbase, on the outskirts of Saigon, was the most important.

GATEWAY TO SAIGON

By the 1930s, Tan Son Nhut was the primary air gateway into southern Vietnam, served by carriers such as Air-Orient. It became an **American base** in 1961, and in 1967 became the headquarters of United States' Military Assistance Command Vietnam (MACV).



AVIATION POSTER

The Mini Tet was the second NVA offensive in 1968. Striking against more than a hundred targets, it was also called Little Tet, the May Offensive, or Phase Two of the Tet Offensive. Fighting was especially fierce in and around Saigon—where a combined Viet Cong and NVA force captured part of Tan Son Nhut airbase—as well as Kham Duc in the Central Highlands.

The NVA's attack on Saigon unfolded in the hours before dawn on May 6, as communist troops infiltrated the city via several routes, including Phu Tho racetrack and the French cemetery on the western edge of Tan Son Nhut. Using rockets, mortars, sniper fire, and ground troops, Viet Cong units attacked the western and southern perimeters of the base and engaged US and ARVN troops in heavy fighting. Although parts of the airfield were damaged by rocket fire, the defenders responded quickly and by late afternoon had stemmed the attack.